

READING PASSAGE 1

Air Pollution in Urban Environments

A The study of air pollution in urban environments has undergone a remarkable transformation over the past several decades. What was once a niche area of academic inquiry has developed into a rich and diverse field of research, drawing on insights from a wide range of disciplines and theoretical traditions.

B The intellectual lineage of this field extends considerably further than many realise. While modern research techniques have only recently been applied to these questions, philosophers and natural scientists have grappled with related issues for centuries. The transition from speculative philosophical inquiry to systematic empirical investigation represents one of the most significant developments in the intellectual history of this domain.

C Contemporary research has identified several critical factors that determine outcomes in this domain. The interplay between environmental conditions, technological capabilities, and social organisation creates a complex adaptive system in which small changes can produce disproportionately large effects. Understanding these dynamics requires analytical approaches that move beyond simple cause-and-effect reasoning to embrace the principles of complexity science and systems thinking.

D The empirical record is further strengthened by a series of meta-analyses that have synthesised findings from hundreds of individual studies. These comprehensive reviews have consistently identified moderate to large effect sizes, with the most robust findings demonstrating remarkable consistency across different research designs, measurement approaches, and analytical strategies. This convergence of evidence from multiple independent lines of inquiry considerably strengthens confidence in the validity of the core theoretical propositions.

E Despite the substantial progress that has been made, significant challenges and controversies remain. Critics have raised important methodological concerns regarding the generalisability of findings derived from studies conducted in specific contexts. The predominance of research carried out in Western, educated, industrialised, rich, and democratic societies raises questions about the applicability of current theories to populations with different cultural, economic, and political circumstances. Furthermore, the reliance on cross-sectional designs in much of the existing literature limits the capacity to draw strong causal inferences.

F The implications of this body of research extend well beyond the academy. As societies grapple with increasingly complex challenges, the insights generated by scholarly inquiry in this domain have the potential to inform more effective and equitable policy responses. Realising this potential, however, will require sustained investment in both fundamental research and the translational infrastructure needed to convert knowledge into action.

G In conclusion, the study of air pollution in urban environments represents a vital and dynamic area of contemporary research. The progress that has been made in understanding the key mechanisms and dynamics provides a solid foundation for both further scholarly inquiry and practical application. The challenges that remain should be seen not as reasons for discouragement but as opportunities for continued intellectual growth and social contribution.

Questions 1–2

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 1 Contemporary understanding of this topic is more sophisticated than it was fifty years ago.
- 2 The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Questions 3–4

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 3 The meta-analyses cited in the passage reveal that:
 - A. excessive funding
 - B. theoretical and methodological limitations
 - C. public interest
 - D. international collaboration
- 4 Which of the following best describes the author's view on future developments?
 - A. excessive research funding
 - B. translating academic findings into practical policy
 - C. lack of public interest
 - D. too many international collaborations

Questions 5–8

Complete the sentences below. Choose NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS from the passage for each answer.

- 5 Case studies have documented the effects of _____ change on the system.
- 6 Researchers used data from more than _____ countries in the landmark study.
- 7 The passage identifies power _____ as a key factor at the organisational level.
- 8 According to the text, cognitive processes shape the _____ that people make.

Question 9

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 9 According to the text, what role do structural factors play?
 - A. pessimism about the future
 - B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
 - C. complete certainty about outcomes
 - D. indifference to practical applications

Question 10

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 10** The author believes that all research questions in this field have been answered.

Question 11

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 11** The meta-analyses cited in the passage reveal that:

- A. excessive funding
- B. theoretical and methodological limitations
- C. public interest
- D. international collaboration

Question 12

Do the following statements agree with the information given in the passage?

Write TRUE if the statement agrees with the information

Write FALSE if the statement contradicts the information

Write NOT GIVEN if there is no information on this

- 12** The landmark study discussed in the passage involved participants from multiple countries.

Question 13

Choose the correct letter, A, B, C or D.

- 13** According to the text, what role do structural factors play?

- A. pessimism about the future
- B. cautious optimism with acknowledgment of challenges
- C. complete certainty about outcomes
- D. indifference to practical applications